Brainmaxxing: 15 Ways to Get Smarter

Channel: Brandon Carter · Published: Oct 12, 2026 · Watch: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=eXqFNdTspts Source: full transcript

📋 Executive Summary

Brandon Carter argues that optimizing the brain—not just the body—is the real lever for success in money, business, and life, and walks through 15 concrete, study-backed strategies across diet, environment, sleep, exercise, and supplements.

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🧠 Introduction: Why Brainmaxxing Matters 0:00

- Brandon frames the video as a counterpoint to the "looksmaxxing" trend—improving appearance is fine, but improving the mind is what actually drives wealth, success, and life quality
- His personal credibility claim:
  - Grew up in the poor neighborhoods of South Chicago
  - Built multiple businesses generating millions, one generating tens of millions
  - Built a large social media empire
  - Attributes all of it to how he used and developed his mind

- Has also taught **thousands of people** to build successful online fitness businesses using the same mental frameworks
- Core thesis: maximize cognitive capacity and you can apply it to every area—body, relationships, business, parenting, and especially income

🍽️ Tip 1: Manage Glucose to Avoid Mental Crashes 1:06

- The after-lunch "food coma" is caused by glucose spikes and the insulin response:
  - When blood glucose exceeds **110 mg/dL**, the pancreas releases insulin
  - Insulin strips glucose from everywhere it can—including the brain—causing mental sluggishness
- Three practical strategies to stabilize glucose without going keto:
  - **Never eat carbs alone** — always pair them with protein; this blunts the insulin response and keeps glucose more stable
  - **Take cinnamon capsules** before a high-carb meal — a study shows cinnamon measurably stabilizes blood glucose levels
  - **Delay carbs to later in the day** — eat your carb portion after you finish work; glucose will rise at night when drowsiness doesn't matter since you're about to sleep anyway
- Bonus tool: **Keto Aid** (exogenous ketone esters, not salts)
  - Brandon states this is not a paid promotion—he buys it himself
  - Ketone esters are far more concentrated and powerful than ketone salts sold in stores
  - Use a small amount before a focus session even if you're not on keto
  - Also suppresses hunger during fasting or dieting

🥑 Tip 2: Consider Ketosis (or Mimic Its Benefits) 1:49

- Brandon has been on a ketogenic diet for **11 years** with no cheat meals for nearly **4 years**
- How ketosis works:
  - In the absence of glucose, the liver converts dietary fat or stored body fat into **ketones**
  - Ketones become the body's primary fuel source
  - Even at sub-10% body fat there's enough stored fat to produce a continuous ketone supply
- Historical note: the ketogenic diet was **invented by doctors in the 1920s** specifically for brain health—used to treat childhood epilepsy when available drugs were too harsh; seizures stopped almost immediately once children were put on keto
- Adaptation phase caveat: the first ~2 weeks on keto feel bad (weakness, fatigue) as the body learns to produce ketones
- Brandon acknowledges most viewers won't go keto, so the other tips provide similar benefits

💧 Tip 3: Drink More Water 5:05

- A cited study shows that **mild dehydration (~1.6% body water loss**—from sweat, environment, or simply not drinking enough—causes significant cognitive decline in men
- Brandon's personal intake: **1.5–2 gallons per day** (he is 200 lbs, 6'2", highly active, living in humid Miami)
- His recommendation for others: at least **1 gallon per day**
- Practical tip: keep water nearby at all times

> "Most people are walking around dehydrated. You guys are not drinking enough water."

⏱️ Tip 4: Daily Intermittent Fasting 5:49

- Brandon practiced **16-hour daily fasting for 5 consecutive years** before switching to keto
- A cited study put adults on intermittent fasting for **8 weeks**:
  - Their brains appeared younger on MRI scans
  - They significantly outperformed a control group (eating normally) on memory tasks and executive function tests
- Mechanism: likely induces mild ketosis, especially with consistent 16-hour fasts over time
- Even without full keto, repeated 16-hour fasts probably push the body into ketosis
- Brandon's view: IF is a practical way to get many of the same brain benefits as keto without the strict dietary change

🌬️ Tip 5: Clean Your Air with a HEPA Filter 7:17

- Study 1 (randomized trial, recent): people given a **HEPA air purifier for one month** scored **12% higher** on cognitive flexibility and cognition tests vs. a control group given a fake/sham filter
- Study 2: HEPA filters installed in **Los Angeles schools** — all students began scoring noticeably higher on tests
- Budget alternative: simply **open a window**
- Harvard study on CO_2 and decision-making:
  - Office workers were placed in controlled environments; air was changed without their knowledge
  - With clean air: decision-making scores rose **31%**
  - With extra-clean/fresh air: scores rose **101%** — literally doubled
  - Mechanism: stale air accumulates CO_2 (the gas we exhale); when CO_2 levels exceed oxygen in a room, cognitive function slows

🪟 Tip 6: Monitor CO_2 and Ventilate Your Space 8:44

- Brandon keeps **CO_2 monitors** in three rooms: his main office, a second office, and his recording studio
- Rule: if CO_2 reading exceeds **600–700 ppm**, open a window immediately
- Personal trade-off: he opens floor-to-ceiling windows in Miami heat, causing him to sweat on camera — "I'd rather be hot than stupid"

☀️ Tip 7: Get Morning Sunlight 10:09

- Brandon walks along the ocean every morning — incidentally sees wildlife (manatees, dolphins, peacocks)
- Study: workers wore light-measuring devices; those with **more morning sunlight exposure**:
  - Fell asleep faster
  - Had higher-quality sleep
  - Were less prone to depression
- Key insight: brain optimization isn't just about cognition — **mood matters too**
  - "A sleepy genius won't accomplish what an alert fool will."
- Morning sunlight supports daytime energy AND nighttime sleep quality

😴 Tip 8: Keep a Consistent Sleep Schedule 11:14

- Study 1: **60,000 people** wore sleep trackers; those with the most regular sleep schedules had a **48% lower risk of death** compared to irregular sleepers
- Study 2 (Harvard undergrads): students with regular sleep patterns earned significantly better grades; irregular sleep was one of the only factors correlated with poor academic performance — linked to disrupted circadian rhythms
- Brandon's personal sleep optimization toolkit (drawn largely from the book *Why We Sleep*):
  - Keep the bedroom **very cold**
  - Use **blackout curtains**
  - **Shower before bed**
- Additional tip (from a study, not in the book): **write down your to-do list for the next day before sleeping** — study participants fell asleep significantly faster when they did this
- Once a regular schedule is established, the body naturally begins to feel tired at the same time each night

🏃 Tip 9: Exercise to Grow Your Brain 12:42

- References a book read ~3 years ago detailing how exercise improves cognitive performance in depth
- A cited study: physical training **increases the volume of the hippocampus** — the brain region responsible for memory — which directly improves memory function
- The more you move your body, the better your brain performs

🚶 Tip 10: Time Exercise Around Learning and Creativity 13:26

- **For memory/retention**: exercise **4 hours after learning** something new significantly improves memory retention (cited study)
- **For fast learning**: doing **two short sprints before studying** helps people learn **20% faster** (cited study) — described as something almost nobody knows
- **For creativity**: a Stanford study found that **walking increases creativity by 60%**

- Applies while walking — you become 60% more creative during the walk itself
- Brandon walks the Atlantic coast every morning while brainstorming
- He calls his AI brainstorming walks **"Claude walks"** — he talks through ideas with Claude (the AI) while walking to develop them

💊 Tip 11: Creatine Monohydrate 14:31

- Standard disclaimer: consult your doctor before taking any supplement (delivered humorously but sincerely)
- Study 1: **a single dose of creatine** kept people significantly more focused throughout the night even without sleep
- Study 2 (meta-analysis of **8 different trials**): creatine significantly improved **memory and focus** in adults
- Brandon's view: everyone should take creatine for brain benefits alone, regardless of whether they exercise
- **Dosing nuance** (based on Dr. Rhonda Patrick's research):
  - Standard muscle-building dose: **5 grams/day**
  - For brain health: approximately **20 grams/day** is suggested by the data
  - Brandon has taken **20 grams of creatine every day for 20 years**

☕ Tip 12: Caffeine 16:42

- Cited study: caffeine significantly improves **attention, coordination, and reaction time**; higher doses outperform lower doses
- Also proven to improve **creativity and problem-solving**
- Brandon's personal intake: **~1,000 mg/day** — acknowledges this is extreme and built up over nearly 30 years since age 16 (he is now 44)
- His observation: virtually every high performer he has encountered is heavily caffeinated
- Counterpoint to health fears: his most recent EKG showed perfect cardiovascular health after ~28 years of heavy caffeine use
- Honest caveat: caffeine is addictive, but it is cheap and the cognitive benefits are well-documented

🩹 Tip 13: Nicotine (Without Smoking) 17:52

- Cited study: nicotine improved **performance, speed, and cognition** — "made humans better at everything"
- **Critical distinction**: smoking delivers nicotine but will kill you; the nicotine itself is the beneficial compound
- Delivery methods Brandon recommends (not smoking):
  - Lozenges
  - Zyn (nicotine pouches)
  - Vaping (as a lesser evil)
  - **Nicotine patches** — his preferred method during deep work sessions
- Brandon says he almost always has a nicotine patch on when recording or working

- **Pro tip**: remove the patch before sleeping — forgetting to do so causes mid-night overstimulation and ruined sleep (he learned this the hard way)
- Alex Hormozi comparison: Hormozi compared nicotine to Adderall; Brandon disagrees slightly — "Adderall makes you feel like a god; nicotine makes you feel like one of God's soldiers"

💉 Tip 14: Modafinil (Prescription) 19:41

- Requires a prescription — Brandon is fully serious here about consulting a doctor (the only legal way to obtain it)
- What it is: a narcolepsy medication that **blocks receptors in the brain that signal tiredness**, producing wakefulness and alertness
- Mechanism analogy:
  - Adderall = flooring the gas pedal
  - Modafinil = lifting your foot off the brake — smoother, gentler forward movement
- Cited studies show modafinil significantly improves **cognitive function and wakefulness**, and also makes tasks feel more enjoyable
- Brandon's preference: he strongly prefers modafinil over Adderall for regular use
- Adderall use case: **emergency only** (critical deadlines) — too addictive for regular use
- Modafinil addiction profile: low — Brandon can stop for weeks with **zero withdrawal symptoms** and restart without issue
- He takes it on work days, skips it on off days with no problem

> "It's been a real cheat code for me and it doesn't seem to be addictive."

- Final call to action: Brandon asks viewers to comment which of the tips they've tried or plan to try